

Congo

Free ways to help, and the context behind them.

Where things stand. Fighting continues in the east. The Washington agreement between the DRC and Rwanda (June 2025) and the Doha framework with M23 (November 2025) have not ended it. In August 2026 the government and M23 agreed a roadmap for talks, and the UN has warned of growing drone use by both sides. An Ebola outbreak declared an international health emergency in May has passed 7,400 confirmed cases and 3,600 deaths, mostly in Ituri and North Kivu (ECDC, 17 September).

Checked 21 September 2026. Every link goes to its own source.

Displaced 7,000,000+

LISTEN

Start with the music.

Streams and album sales pay artists directly. These are starting points, not a canon.

Fally Ipupa (<https://fally-ipupa.com/>)

Kinshasa-born rumba and ndombolo star. A good first listen.

Congolese rumba (<https://www.afropop.org/audio-programs/congolese-music-the-fifth-generation>)

On UNESCO's intangible heritage list since 2021. Afropop traces it from rumba to Kinshasa's newest sounds, including Jupiter & Okwess and Pierre Kwenders.

Staff Benda Bilili (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Staff_Benda_Bilili)

Street musicians from Kinshasa, many of them paraplegic. They contributed to the Enough Project's Raise Hope for Congo compilation.

KOKOKO! (<https://www.kokokomusic.com/about>)

A Kinshasa collective playing instruments built from scrap.

Innoss'B (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Music_of_the_Democratic_Republic_of_the_Congo)

Born and raised in Goma. Congolese rhythms with hip-hop and R&B.

Lexxus Legal (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Music_of_the_Democratic_Republic_of_the_Congo)

Co-founder of Pensée Brute Noire, a pioneer of combative, protest-oriented Congolese rap.

LOOK

Look at the art.

Painters and sculptors who carry the place with them.

Beauté Congo, 1926–2015 (<https://fondationcartier.com/en/exhibitions/beaute-congo-1926-2015-congo-kitoko?lang=en>)

A century of Congolese painting, sculpture, photography, and comics in one exhibition guide, including Sammy Baloji.

Chéri Samba (<https://cherisamba.net/>)

Founder of Kinshasa’s “popular painting”: bright canvases with text on everyday life, politics, and corruption.

Bodys Isek Kingelez (<https://www.magnin-a.com/en/exhibitions/233-kings-of-kin/overview/>)

1948–2015. Built utopian cities from scrap; MoMA gave him a retrospective.

Eza Possibles (https://domusweb.it/en/news/2015/07/09/beaute_congo_1926_2015_congo_kitoko.html)

A Kinshasa collective founded in 2003 by painters including Pathy Tshindele and Kura Shomali.

READ

Good news, and reporting you can check.

Stories of people building something, then outlets that show their sources.

GOOD NEWS

Small steps toward peace (<https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/7/dr-congo-releases-15-prisoners-to-m23-rebels-as-part-of-doha-peace-process>)

In August 2026 the Red Cross helped move 15 prisoners to M23, the first known transfer under the Doha deal. A confidence step, not a settlement.

Mountain gorillas are recovering (<https://www.wlrn.org/npr-breaking-news/2026-06-06/a-park-famed-for-rare-gorillas-gears-up-to-fight-ebola-and-protect-its-primates>)

From 350 in 1985 to 1,200+ across Uganda, Rwanda, and DR Congo. Virunga's rangers guard them through violence and an Ebola outbreak (NPR, June 2026).

Panzi has treated survivors since 1999 (<https://panzifoundation.org/>)

A Congolese-run hospital and foundation in Bukavu, founded by Dr. Denis Mukwege, 2018 Nobel Peace laureate.

REPORTING

Actualite.cd (<https://actualite.cd/>)

Congolese news outlet covering the DRC, in French.

Radio Okapi (<https://www.radiookapi.net/>)

Radio reporting from across the DRC.

ACAPS: DRC (<https://www.acaps.org/en/countries/drc>)

Displacement and needs analysis for the DRC.

HRW World Report 2026: DR Congo (<https://www.hrw.org/world-report/2026/country-chapters/democratic-republic-of-congo>)

Abuses and the conflict, year in review.

FOLLOW

People and pages, close to the ground.

Follow widely and check claims against a second source. Local groups organize mostly on Facebook, X, and WhatsApp; the sites below lead to their pages.

PEOPLE AND PAGES

Eastern Congo Initiative (<https://www.easterncongo.org/>)

Funds Congolese-led groups. On X: @EastCongoNews.

Panzi Foundation (<https://panzifoundation.org/>)

News from Bukavu and Dr. Mukwege's advocacy.

Julienne Lusenge (<https://www.nobelwomensinitiative.org/meet-the-inspiring-women-activists-of-the-drc>)

Names commanders in public and leads a coalition of Congolese women's organizations.

Virunga National Park (<https://virunga.org/>)

Rangers, gorillas, and the Virunga Alliance's development work.

LOCAL GROUPS

LUCHA (<https://frontlinedefenders.org/en/profile/lucha>)

A youth-led, nonviolent citizen movement founded in Goma in 2012. Front Line Defenders award, 2018.

HEAL Africa (<https://healafrica.org/>)

Hospital and community programs in Goma, founded by Congolese surgeon Jo Lusi and Lyn Lusi.

GIVE

Give where it lands.

We list organizations, not individual crowdfunding pages, which are the hardest to check. Rising Tigers doesn't handle your money.

Panzi Foundation (<https://panzifoundation.org/donate/>)

Trauma surgery, mental health care, legal aid, job training. Congolese-run.

Donate (<https://panzifoundation.org/donate/>)

HEAL Africa (<https://healafrica.org/>)

Hospital care and community programs in Goma. HEAL Africa USA is a 501(c)(3).

Visit (<https://healafrica.org/>)

Eastern Congo Initiative (<https://www.easterncongo.org/give>)

Grants to Congolese-led organizations, including HEAL Africa.

Donate (<https://www.easterncongo.org/give>)

Doctors Without Borders (MSF) (<https://www.doctorswithoutborders.org/>)

Emergency medical care, including nine Ebola treatment centers (<https://www.doctorswithoutborders.org/latest/ebola-disease-outbreak-2026-how-msf-responding>) across five provinces.

International Rescue Committee (<https://www.rescue.org/>)

Emergency aid and protection.

UNHCR (<https://www.unhcr.org/donate-unhcr.html>)

Shelter and protection for displaced people.

Check any charity before you give: [Charity Navigator](#), [CharityWatch](#), and [Candid](#).

Be wary of anyone who asks for gift cards, crypto, or a wire transfer.

BUY

Buy from the people who make it.

Buying supports makers. To fund relief, use Give.

Congo Clothing Company (<https://panzifoundation.org/?p=401>)

Denim and prints inspired by Kuba patterns. Each jacket sold funds a sewing machine for a Panzi survivor.

Equal Exchange coffee (<https://equalexchange.coop/>)

Coffee from SOPACDI, a Congolese farmers' co-op. Per Panzi, Equal Exchange gives \$2 per bag to Panzi.

Panzi jewelry (<https://panzifoundation.org/?p=1718>)

Gemstone and wood jewelry made in Panzi's workshop, part of its ethical-supply work.

Zapenda (<https://missingperspectives.com/?p=420>)

Clothing made in Congo by war survivors. Founder Stella Safari also has a store in Detroit.

ESIMBI (<https://businessday.ng/bd-weekender/article/tina-lobondi-from-fashion-to-philanthropy-putting-congo-on-the-map/>)

A nonprofit by designer Tina Lobondi teaching arts and fashion to children in Congo.

UNDERSTAND

A short history, with the disputes marked.

Dates and figures come from the sources linked; where sources disagree, the box says so.

1885–1908

King Leopold II runs the Congo Free State as a private colony. Forced labor for rubber kills millions. Belgium takes it over in 1908.

1960

Independence. Prime Minister Patrice Lumumba is killed in January 1961.

1965–1997

Mobutu Sese Seko rules as president of Zaire.

1994

After the Rwandan genocide, more than a million refugees, including some who carried out the killing, cross into eastern Zaire.

1996–2003

Two wars. The second draws about a dozen armies and 30 armed groups. Estimates of the dead run into the millions and are debated.

2012–2013

The first M23 rebellion takes Goma, then is defeated.

2025

M23 returns and takes Goma (January) and Bukavu (February); the UN counted at least 700 killed in the fight for Goma. Washington agreement between the DRC and Rwanda (27 June), Doha declaration with M23 (19 July), Doha framework (15 November).

2026

Talks continue, with a roadmap agreed in Switzerland

(<https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/23/dr-congo-m23-rebels-agree-on-roadmap-for-peace-talks>) in August. Massacres attributed to the ADF continue in Beni and Ituri (Mukwege, June 2026 (<https://ground.news/article/east-of-the-drc-denis-mukwege-condemns-recent-killings-in-the-city-of-beni-and-calls-on-kinshasa-to-emerge-from-a-hypocritical-compassion-tha>)). An Ebola outbreak (<https://www.ecdc.europa.eu/en/ebola-outbreak-democratic-republic-congo-and-uganda>) declared in May has spread through Ituri, North Kivu, and other provinces, amid the fighting.

What's contested

Rwanda denies backing M23. UN experts reported in July 2025 that Rwanda's army played a "critical" role in M23's operations ([AllAfrica](#)).

M23 says it protects Congolese Tutsis from ethnic attacks. The government called it a "terrorist group" until it agreed to talks in 2025.

Death-toll estimates for the 1998–2003 war vary widely.

Start with [HRW's World Report chapter](#) and [ACAPS](#).

DO

Two minutes, no money.

Small, free, specific.

Call, don't post (<https://www.usa.gov/elected-officials>)

Staffers tally calls, not reposts. Say one sentence, then hang up. Find your representatives here.

Keep your phone longer

Phones and laptops rely on Congolese minerals, including coltan from the east. Using a device longer lowers demand. Our article explains the link.

Enough Project (<https://enoughproject.org/>)

Research and campaigns on conflict minerals and atrocity prevention. It ran Raise Hope for Congo.

Read the sources (https://github.com/TahreemK13/Rising_Tigers_Initiative/blob/main/library/sources.md)

Every figure in our article as a plain-text file, with its source and the date we checked it.